

Handle Success Like You Handle Failure: Wrap-Up, featuring Doug Buce

Doug Buce, President & CLO, Boing Dynamics, Inc.

One hallmark of a great leader is their ability to learn from both success and failure. Pat Summitt was equally dedicated to analyzing her team's wins, as well as their losses.

In this module, we have learned three key takeaways about handling success like you handle failure. First, we examined why learning from success is often more difficult than learning from failure. Second, we learned how extraordinary leaders and innovators like Thomas Edison were able to overcome the fear of failure. And finally, in the last segment, we explored how to treat success with the same respect as failure.

Coach Pat Summitt

I don't handle losing very well at all. I get physically ill when I lose. Losing is not a good thing for me at the moment, but it is a great thing for me long-range because it gives me a blueprint for what we need to do and do better.

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You may recall that, in 1996, the Lady Vols won the national championship and by all outward appearances, they were poised to do the same in the '97 season. But the 1997 season, in many respects, was one of Coach Summitt's worst seasons ever. Not only did the Lady Vols lose ten games, but they lost to perennial powerhouse programs like Stanford, Old Dominion, UConn and Louisiana Tech. In fact, some pundits weren't sure if Tennessee would make the postseason tournament at all. But, in a stunning display of grit, determination, and togetherness, the Lady Vols danced through the tournament and defeated UConn in the NCAA regionals and went on to defeat Old Dominion for the national championship.

Pat and her Lady Vols learned how to turn failure and losses into wins. Coach Summitt said, "You don't win basketball games on the first shots. You win them on second and third and fourth shots. Follow-up is the secret to continued success in anything." Are you giving your all on your second, third and fourth shots? As Pat reminds us, you can't have continued success without experiencing failure.